

Topic 2: ChatGPT

2.1 What is ChatGPT?

- ChatGPT is a conversational AI assistant built on OpenAI's GPT models -- the most widely used AI tool in the world
- Free tier: GPT-4o mini -- fast, capable, handles most everyday writing, research, and coding tasks
- ChatGPT Plus (\$20/month): GPT-4o -- more powerful reasoning, image input, image generation (DALL-E 3), web browsing
- ChatGPT Team / Enterprise: data privacy guarantees, higher usage limits, admin controls for organisations
- Try it: <https://chat.openai.com>

2.2 Core Features

- Custom instructions: set persistent context once ('I am a software engineer; always respond in Python 3') -- applies to all chats
- Memory: ChatGPT can remember facts across conversations (opt-in); manage or clear in settings
- Custom GPTs: create or use pre-configured AI assistants with specific instructions and tools (ChatGPT Plus)
- File and image upload: analyse PDFs, spreadsheets, images, and code files directly
- Web browsing (Plus): searches Bing in real time for current events and up-to-date information
- DALL-E 3 integration (Plus): generate images directly in chat from a text description

2.3 Getting the Most from ChatGPT

- Be specific: provide role, task, format, tone, length, and audience in your prompts
- Iterate: most great outputs come after 2--3 refinements, not a single prompt
- Verify facts: ChatGPT confidently states incorrect information -- always check statistics, dates, and citations
- Don't paste sensitive data: use ChatGPT Team or local models for confidential work
- Use for what it does best: writing, brainstorming, code explanation, summarisation, and drafting

Effective prompt example:

```
'You are a senior project manager.  
Write a professional email to my team of 5 software engineers  
summarising today's sprint planning meeting.  
Key points: 3 sprint goals agreed, deadline is Friday,  
Alice leads the API work.  
Tone: friendly but focused. Length: under 150 words.'
```

2.4 Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Trusting factual claims without verification -- always check specific numbers, citations, and recent events
 - Pasting sensitive or confidential data into the public free/Plus tier
 - Accepting the first output without iterating -- refine with follow-up instructions
 - Using it only for writing -- explore it for data analysis, code review, research, and planning
 - Ignoring Custom Instructions -- setting context once saves significant time across many conversations
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